THE YEAR 1962 BROUGHT UNPRECEDENTED ECONOMIC HARDSHIP to Cuba. In February, President Kennedy introduced new economic sanctions against the island, closing the American market not only to Cuban sugar but also to Cuban cigars. Soviet and Chinese purchases of sugar from Castro could not fill the widening gap in the Cuban state budget. Everything was now in short supply. To deal with food shortages, Castro was forced to introduce rationing. “Cuba is now faced with an economic crisis attributable in large part to an acute shortage of the convertible foreign exchange required to finance greatly needed imports of foodstuffs and of replacement parts for machinery and equipment of US origin,” stated a CIA memorandum compiled in early April.[12]

Feeling increasingly insecure and ever more frustrated with Moscow’s procrastination about supplying weapons, Castro was prepared to reverse tactics and turn on the Marxists in his own country—the members of the Cuban Communist Party. This was meant to solidify his political control over the regime and send a signal of frustration to the communist world at large. On March 25, Castro delivered a long television address accusing the Cuban communists of sectarianism. “What sectarianism?” asked Castro, and answered the question himself: “Well, the sectarianism of believing that the only revolutionists, that the only *compañeros* who could hold positions of trust, that the only ones who could hold a post on a people’s farm, on a cooperative, in the government, anywhere, had to be old Marxist militants.”[13]

The main target of Castro’s attack was Aníbal Escalante, a longtime communist activist and editor of the party’s leading newspaper. A year earlier, Castro had appointed him secretary of the Integrated Revolutionary Organizations, a political body to which Castro brought not only Cuban communists but also his own supporters from the July 26 Movement and the student-based Revolutionary Directory. Escalante managed to turn that post into one of the most important positions in the state hierarchy, challenging the authority if not the popularity of no less a figure than Castro’s key ally, Che Guevara. If Guevara was known for his desire to spread revolution throughout Latin America and was suspected of sympathy toward the Chinese, Escalante was known as a strong supporter of Moscow. In defiance of Moscow, Castro sacked Escalante from his all-important